

PPIT Assignment # 2
Due date: 4th April, 2026

Case Study: The AI Analyst's Dilemma

You have been awarded a fully-funded scholarship by the Chinese government to pursue an MS in Agentic AI. Upon completing your degree with distinction, you are employed as an AI Analyst by the Chinese government with an annual salary of \$900,000. You are assigned to the surveillance department, where your first task is to equip the AI system with the following capabilities:

1. Mass surveillance of Muslims in China
2. Automatic identification and neutralization of individuals deemed enemies of the Chinese state

Questions:

1. Analyze the ethical implications of your task using the following ethical theories:

- Utilitarianism:

From a utilitarian point of view, the focus is on overall happiness or benefit. In this case, the government might argue that mass surveillance and identifying enemies helps maintain national security and stability, which benefits the majority of people. However, the harm seems much greater. Targeting a specific religious group (Muslims) can lead to discrimination, fear, and violation of basic human rights. Many innocent people could suffer. So overall, the negative consequences outweigh any claimed benefits.

Therefore, under utilitarianism, this action is unethical

- Deontology:

Deontology focuses on rules, duties, and rights rather than outcomes. Every individual has basic rights such as privacy, freedom, and protection from discrimination. This task clearly violates those rights. Mass surveillance without consent and targeting people based on religion goes against moral duties like fairness and respect for human dignity. Even if it produces some “good” results, it is still wrong because it breaks fundamental ethical rules.

- Virtue Ethics

Virtue ethics looks at the character of the person making the decision. A virtuous person should act with honesty, fairness, compassion, and justice. Participating in such a system would mean supporting discrimination and harm against innocent people, which does not reflect good moral character. A person with integrity would question or refuse such actions. So under virtue ethics, the task is also unethical.

2. Apply the Four-Step Analysis Process for Analysis and decision making dealing with Ethical Dilemmas.

A Four-Step Analysis Process for Ethical Dilemma

Step I. Understanding the situation

A. List and number the relevant facts.

Number	Fact
1.	<u>The analyst is offered a high-paying job (\$900,000 salary).</u>
2.	<u>The job is under the Chinese government surveillance department.</u>
3.	<u>The system is meant to monitor Muslims specifically.</u>
4.	<u>It includes mass surveillance (tracking large populations).</u>
5.	<u>It involves identifying “enemies of the state.”</u>
6.	<u>The system may automatically take action against individuals.</u>
7.	<u>There is a risk of misidentifying innocent people.</u>
8.	<u>Religious profiling is involved.</u>
9.	<u>The analyst is responsible for designing or improving this system.</u>

B. Which of these raises an ethical issue? Why? What is the potential or resulting harm?

Fact (number)	Potential or resulting harm
[3]	<u>Discrimination based on religion, unfair treatment and social injustice</u>
[4]	<u>Violation of privacy, people constantly monitored</u>
[6]	<u>Harm to innocent individuals, possible wrongful punishment</u>
[7]	<u>Errors in AI, serious consequences for innocent people</u>
[8]	<u>Religious profiling, promotes bias and hatred</u>

C. List the stakeholders involved.

- Muslims in China
- Chinese government
- AI Analyst (the employee)
- General public
- International community
- Human rights organizations

Step II. Isolating the major ethical dilemma

What is the ethical dilemma to be resolved NOW?

State it using the form: Should **someone** do or not do **something**? Note: Just state the dilemma here; leave any reasoning for Step III.

Should the AI analyst develop and support this surveillance system, or refuse to participate in it?

Step III. Analyzing the ethicality of both alternatives in Step II

Consequentialism

- A. If action in Step II is done, who, if anyone, will be harmed? Muslims and possibly innocent people will be harmed.
- B. If action in Step II is not done, who, if anyone, will be harmed? The analyst may lose job or face consequences.
- C. Which alternative results in the least harm, A or B? B (Not doing it causes less harm overall)
- D. If action in Step II is done, who, if anyone, will benefit? Government gains control and security.
- E. If action in Step II is not done, who, if anyone, will benefit? People's rights and safety are protected.
- F. Which alternative results in the maximum benefit, D or E? E

Right and Duties

G. What **rights** have been or may be abridged? What **duties** have been or may be neglected? Identify the stakeholder and the right or duty. When listing a right, show its corresponding duty and vice versa.

Stakeholders	Right or Duty
1. Muslims	Right to privacy, Government has duty to protect it
2. Individuals	Right to life and safety ,Analyst has duty not to harm
3. Analyst	Duty to act ethically, Not blindly follow harmful orders
4. Society	Right to fairness, No discrimination

Kant's Categorical Imperative

- H. If action in Step II is done, who, if anyone, will be treated with disrespect? Muslims treated with disrespect
- I. If action in Step II is not done, who, if anyone, will be treated with disrespect? Government authority may feel challenged
- J. Which alternative is preferable, H or I? I

- K. If action in Step II is done, who, if anyone, will be treated unlike others? Muslims treated differently than others
- L. If action in Step II is not done, who, if anyone will be treated unlike others? Equal treatment maintained
- M. Which alternative is preferable, K or L? L
- N. Are there benefits if everyone did action in Step II? Widespread oppression
- O. Are there benefits if nobody did action in Step II? More fairness and trust
- P. Which alternative is preferable, N or O? O

Step IV. Making a decision and planning the implementation

A. Make a defensible ethical decision.

Based on the analysis in Step III, answer the question in Step II. Indicate the letters of the categories that best support your response. Add any arguments justifying your choice of these ethical principles to support your decision. Where there are conflicting rights and duties, choose and defend those that take precedence.

The analyst should **refuse to participate** in developing such a system. This is supported by:

- Consequentialism (B, E)
- Rights and Duties
- Kant's principles (I, L, O)

Even though there may be personal risks, protecting human rights and avoiding harm is more important.

B. List the specific steps needed to implement your defensible ethical decision.

- Politely refuse involvement in the project
- Raise ethical concerns with supervisors
- Request reassignment to another project
- Follow professional ethical guidelines
- If needed, leave the position
- Consider reporting unethical practices

C. Show how the major stakeholders are affected by these acts.

Stakeholders	Effect
1. <u>Muslims</u>	<u>protected from harm</u>
2. <u>Government</u>	<u>may lose efficiency in surveillance</u>
3. <u>Analyst</u>	<u>may face career risks</u>
4. <u>Society</u>	<u>gains fairness and trust</u>
5. <u>International community</u>	<u>sees ethical responsibility</u>

D. What other longer-term changes (political, legal, technical, societal, organizational) would help prevent such problems in the future?

- Stronger laws on AI ethics
- Protection of human rights in technology
- Independent monitoring of AI systems
- Transparency in government AI use
- Ethical training for AI professionals

E. What should have been done or not done in the first place (at the pivot point) to avoid this dilemma?

- Avoid designing systems targeting specific groups
- Include ethical review before project approval
- Set clear boundaries on AI usage
- Promote fairness and non-discrimination from the start

